BASELINE REPORT

SADA, DUNGARPUR

Evaluation Supported By:

Ariel Gomez, Future Faculty Fellow, Northeastern University
Nirved Kumar, PhD Scholar, IIM Ahmedabad
Vinay Jha, PhD Scholar, IIM Ahmedabad
Yatin Diwakar, PhD Scholar, IIT Bombay

deep
Devising an End to Extreme Poverty

Table of Contents

Introduction	03
Our Model | Unconditional Cash Transfers	04
Objectives of the Sada Project	05
Expected Impact	06
Research - Tools & Methodology	07
About Sada	08
The Implementation Process	19
Learnings	23
Stories From Sada	25
The On-ground Team	27
Conclusion	28
Way Forward	28
Appendix	29

Introduction

Globally, our understanding of poverty has expanded beyond monetary distress, to include factors of general well-being (health, education, and living standards). There are ~200 mn people in India living in multidimensional poverty. They lack access to housing, sanitation and opportunities for economic mobility; and are often mired in high levels of debt. The economies that they inhibit continue to remain cash starved, inhibiting any potential to even think of, let alone invest in their own development and well being.

The chronic stress of making ends meet can crush their hopes and imagination, entrapping an entire generation and the next.

In recent years, there is a compelling discourse globally, with 300+[1] studies demonstrating the positive impact of direct cash transfers on poverty eradication. Unconditional cash transfers foster self-reliance and boost economic empowerment. Strong evidence from historical and existing programs showcases that there is a positive impact on human development through education, improvement in health and nutrition, and enhancement of women's economic activity and labor supply, in communities of implementation. New findings from the world's largest UBI study also reveal how lumpsum transfers go a long way in improving socio-economic outcomes for those living below the poverty line. The same studies can also dispel the myths that cash transfers induce dependencies, laziness, and a rise in negative consumption. Most importantly this program provides recipients the ability to choose their own version of security.

Despite conversations across the world, there has been a minimal uptake of this model in India, especially within philanthropy and civil society. There are currently only two programs engaged with models of unconditional cash transfers - WorkFREE[2] and Project DEEP.

The government, however, has been warming up to the idea, with certain schemes like PM Kisan Samman Nidhi[3] (INR 6000 a year to farmers), Gruh Lakshmi Scheme[4] in Karnataka (INR 2000 per month to women) and Rythu Bandhu[5] in Telangana (INR 5000 per acre, per season to farmers), amongst others.

[1] Cash Research Explorer [300+ Scholarly Articles] | GiveDirectly
[2] WorkFREE
[3] PM Kisan
[4] Gruha Lakshmi Scheme
[5] Rythu Bandhu Agriculture Investment Support Scheme

Our Model | Unconditional Cash Transfers

Our program entails a transfer for INR 65,000 to 112 households in Sada, a tribal village in Dungarpur district, Rajasthan.

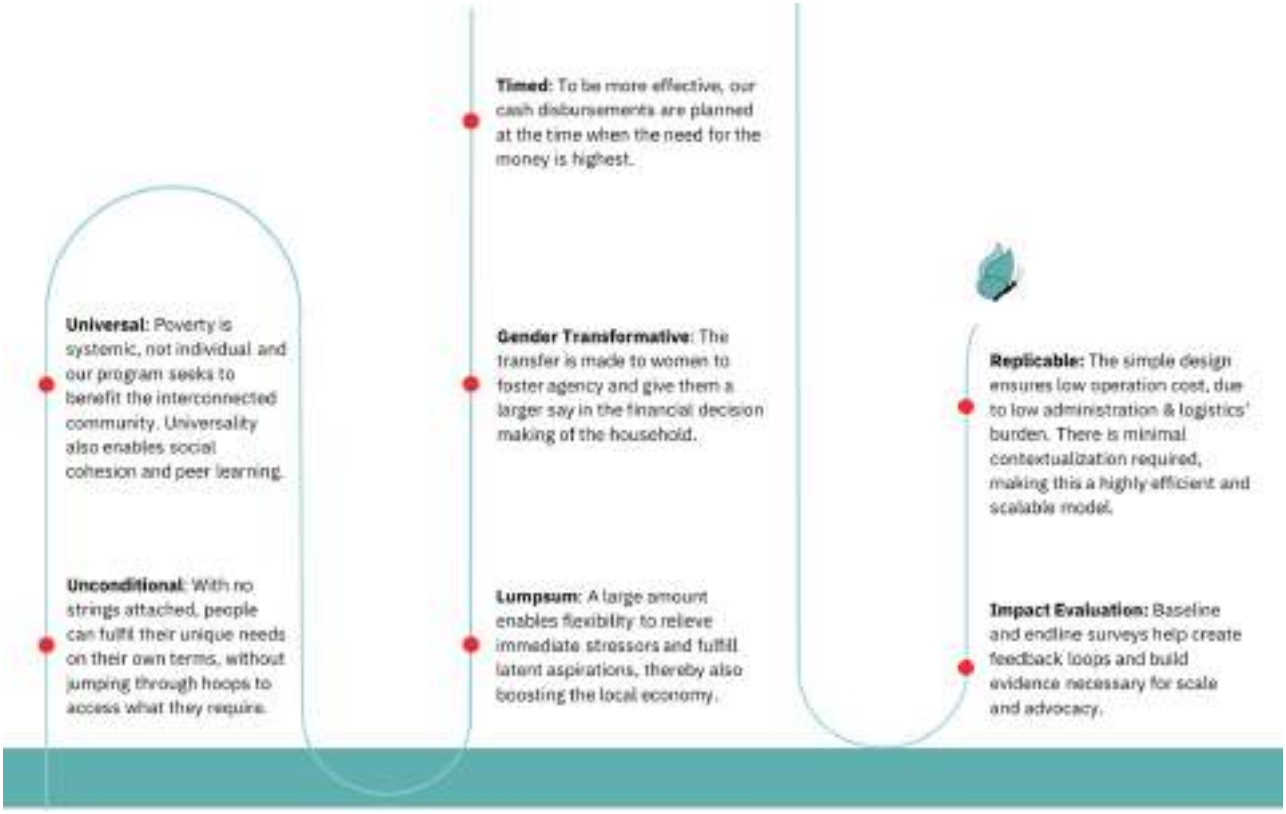


Image 1: Features of the program

The current program was implemented in partnership with Rajasthan Shram Sarathi Association ('Shram Sarathi'). They have been operating in the rural and tribal areas of South Rajasthan since 2007, providing financial products and services to the indigent communities.

After having worked across the spectrum of microfinance to returnable grants, unconditional cash transfers are a natural extension of the spectrum for Shram Sarathi. Their understanding of the demographics, where credit is not an affordable option, made them interested in unconditional cash transfers. We are aligned that unconditional cash transfers can give marginalised households the economic foundation required to make the leap from their existing circumstances.

Objectives of the Sada Project

With this program, we aim to put cash back in the hands of people to empower them to carve their own pathway out of poverty.

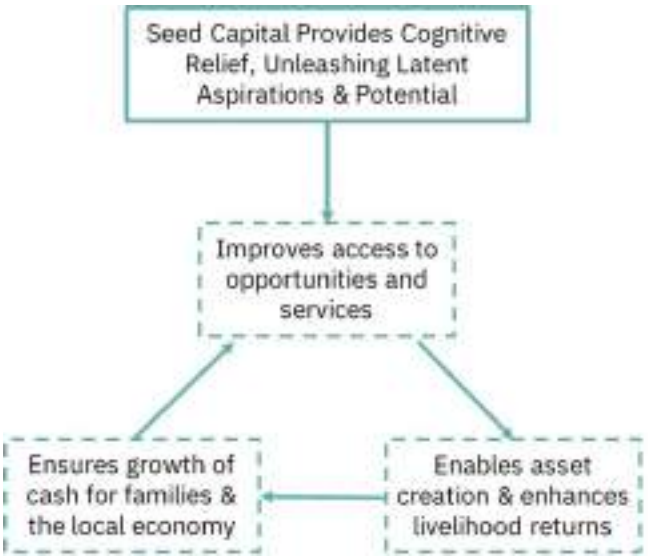


Image 2: Theory of Change

Expected Impact

Transfer of a lumpsum amount results in wealth generation through the creation of assets, which has an intergenerational impact. Our hypothesis is that money will be utilised towards housing, agriculture and enterprise:.

- Improvements in housing which will increase safety, physical health, and mental health. For eg: Those who live in *kucha* (mud) houses may strengthen their homes, which provides safety from inclement weather related crises, insects and animals. Proper housing also allows for more long term and stable migration due to the cognitive relief of knowing that the family back home is safe.
- Investments in agricultural production have the potential for multi-fold impact. For eg: Levelling the uneven land will allow more area under harvest, increasing the amount of food supply for consumption and potentially for sale, increasing the disposable income of families. Creating borewells will ensure water for increased agricultural activity. This increased supply can also be used to grow vegetables in the backyard of the home, especially during the non-farming season (when rice, wheat and other consumption crops are not harvested).
- Cash transfers can also be used to expand existing enterprises or create new ones, increasing and stabilizing income in the long run, thereby smoothing consumption and increasing cognitive well-being.
- People will also use some amounts on ration (daily meals), repaying unhealthy debt, or debt that has a collateral attached, and easing other daily stressors.

Broadly, the utilisation of funds and its outcomes can be classified as below.

-Productive use for livelihood or investment will results in creation of assets, which will yield long term results
-Protective use like housing, security or savings relieves stressors and creates a buffer to weather against future crisis
-Consumption in the form of ration, utility or recreational assets, to fulfil individual wishes and desires

All of these will have a positive impact on individual wellbeing, community upliftment and the business of local economies.

Research - Tools and Methodology

We implemented the program in three hamlets in Sada, Dungarpur in Rajasthan. This report details the findings from the baseline survey conducted in November 2023. At the endline, one year later, we will be able to measure the progress made by the households that received lumpsum transfers.

The baseline survey questionnaire has been created using publicly available and internationally recognised frameworks:

1. Self Reliance Index: This tool contains twelve domains focused on a household's basic needs, resources, and sustainability. Domains measure conditions and assets that increase the likelihood that target populations will be able to continue meeting their needs in the future. While this was originally meant to be administered to refugees, it has been contextualised to suit demographics where we operate.[6]
2. WorkFREE Research Tools: WorkFREE is a multi-method study centred around the creation of a social experiment involving basic income in Hyderabad, India. Their publicly available survey questionnaires and methodology are contextualised for India, and designed by leading scholars in the cash transfer space.[7]
3. Cash Relief Baseline Survey: Cash Relief is the only other organisation that has conducted a pilot in unconditional and universal lumpsum cash transfers in Rajasthan. Indicus Foundation conducted the research for this program, and they were gracious to share their tools and methodologies for our reference, which enabled us to simplify our approach.
4. GHQ-12: The twelve-item General Health Questionnaire (GHQ-12) is intended to screen for general (non-psychotic) mental health problems among primary care patients. We have used a globally recognised tool to be able to generate data that is comparable at a larger scale.[8]

[6] Self-Reliance Index
[7] Research Methods | Workfree
[8] GHQ-12

About Sada

Location

Sada is in the Dungarpur district, Rajasthan. The program was implemented in three adjacent hamlets - Amali phala, Mana Mangari and Kadiya Mangari. It is located about 15kms away from the nearest towns of Aspur and Sabla, where their main market, banking and transport access is. It is part of the Khudarda panchayat.



Demographic

The three hamlets are inhabited by the Meena, an Adivasi community, designated as Scheduled Tribe. In total it comprises 112 households with a population of 505, of which 46% is female. [Note: the survey was conducted with 109 households, due to the unavailability of the rest]

Occupation and Finances

In Sada, while most of the population engages in farming, they grow consumption crops. The main source of income is through migration for men and daily wage farming and MNREGA work for women. 53% men and 43% women are income earners, the rest include children, students, senior citizens and those who are engaged in farming on their own land or women who are unable to work due to domestic responsibilities.

Agriculture: On an average, each family owns ~2.7 *bigha* land (which is roughly 1.7 acres). Sowing and harvest is possible only on 58% of this due to the uneven land. The smaller size of the land parcels is due to large sized families and division between many brothers over generations. There is a dam nearby from which water is released post Diwali every year, providing water to the lands adjacent to the stream. Some landowners suffer due to excess water through leaks in the structure. There is only 1% of families that sometimes sell abundant produce of soybean, especially in years of a good harvest.

Wage Labour: 73% of the families are dependent on circular migration for their income with one or more members travelling to nearby cities to work for a few months. The most common occupations are helpers or cooks at a tea or snacks stall, working in a kirana or clothes store, domestic help or daily wage at construction sites and other odd jobs. Women are mostly enrolled with MNREGA and get about 60 days of work a year earning INR 180 / day, on average.

Number of people bifurcated by migration pattern and type of income

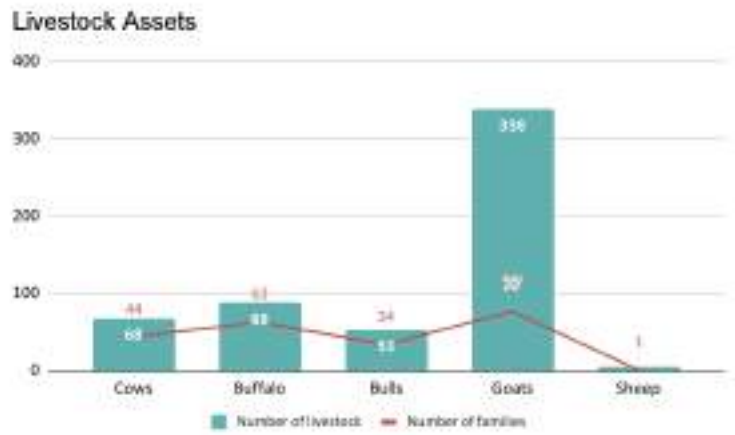
	Daily Wage	**Temporary Wage**	**Permanent Wage**
Local	102	0	2
Commuter Migrant	30	0	1
Circular Migrant	40	52	11

Local: those who engage in daily wage on others' farms or through MGNREGA
Commuter Migrants: those who work in nearby villages and towns, but live at home
Circular Migrants: those who work and stay for a few months in nearby cities of Ahmedabad, Surat, Indore and Mumbai
Daily wage: those who are paid based on the day's work
Temporary: those who are paid a wage, but do not have one constant employer
Permanent: those who are paid a wage and have one constant employer

Own Enterprise: Four families have a shop, three that sell basic snack items and regular stationery, and one that sells women's products like artificial jewellery and cosmetics. Another person is a rickshaw driver, earning his income in Ahmedabad.

Subsidies: 45 out of the 112 households are actively receiving some form of DBT from the government (pension, PM Kisan, education scholarship). Our understanding through conversations is that these are erratic in terms of amount and receipt. (pension amounts are differing in households and for both genders, while they have been discontinued in many cases).

Livestock: 70% of the families own four goats on an average, which are reared and sold to generate income. Some families also own cows and buffaloes, but very few earn a meagre dairy income from those. Mainly the dung from the livestock is used as fertiliser on the fields.



Annual Gross Income: INR 1,07,126
Livelihood investment (raw material for farming, commute for migration and living expenses at destination): INR 31,790
Annual Net Income: INR 75,336

Routine Expenses: Apart from the cost incurred on livelihood, a large share of the expense is that of food, followed by debt repayment. Utilities indicate phone, electricity and other bills, and other expenses are those beyond the routine on clothes, social costs and other home related requirements. The average expense per household is INR 1,16,446.

[Note: this is considerably higher than the average income, and our hypothesis is an over-reporting of food expenses and under-reporting of wages, since there is no availability of written records / budgets. However, there is likely to be some gap between income and expense which is plugged through debt.]



The net income is barely enough to cover the costs, repay debt, and expend on their routine needs. The pandemic also pushed them back further, where not just savings were depleted but costs related to enterprises piled up because investments were sunk and debt piled up. MGNREGA work is erratic, and long term migration is fraught with worry about the situation back home due to *kucha* houses and minimal safety measures. Secondary data shows that average days of employment per household in Rajasthan dropped to 48 in FY24, from 56 in FY23.[9] The folk here are enterprising and support that can boost their economic stability and restore their self confidence will go a long way.

Savings: Savings are typically in the form of some silver jewellery that may have been passed down over generations. As reported in the survey, very few families have some gold jewellery or a balance of upto INR 5,000 in their bank accounts. There are only three families that have more than INR 5,000 and two families that have savings exceeding INR 10,000 in their bank accounts. 12 families have no savings.

[9] https://nregastrep.nic.in/netnrega/homestciti.aspx?state_code=27&state_name=RAJASTHAN

Debt: 88 out of the 109 families have some form of debt. There are 2.3 loans on an average per family, with an average amount of INR 75,159. 58% of the total debt is formal, which means that it is taken from banks, microfinance companies or from the SHG. The remaining 42% is taken from private moneylenders, friends and family, regular vendors or from jewellers against gold or silver. The cumulative debt amounts to INR 66,14,00 for various purposes across housing, agriculture, education, health, social costs (weddings and funerals) and routine expenses.





When asked what debt they would prefer to repay on priority, the responses were mixed, varying from microfinance due to social pressure, loans against assets to bring collateral back (either jewellery or land), or just pay a little to all to keep them at bay.

Banking:

382 people out of 492 have bank accounts, owing to the linkage to MGNREGA and the long standing work of Shram Sarathi on financial inclusion.

Cell phone access:

107 families have atleast one cell phone in the house. 58% of the men and 39% of the women have a cell phone of which 63% men and 28% women have smartphones. Recently the government has provided smartphones to senior women, widows and women who had completed 100 days of MGNREGA[10] work, and yet we see that most of these are either being used by the men or children. One old couple and a woman living alone do not have cell phones.

Infrastructure and Utilities:

106 families own their own land, 3 bigha on an average. However, given the overgrowth and uneven topography, cultivation is possible only on 2 bigha. Only 170 out of the total 291 bigha is generally under harvest.

35 families have a pucca house (stone / brick and mortar), of which only 12 have been built through the Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana - Gramin[11]. 41 families live in kucha houses, and 33 families have construction ongoing through the government scheme. People have ample space to build houses, with big *aangans* where either vegetables can be grown or livestock can be kept. Some people have two houses, one on the fields and one in the village community.

No one has water taps in their house, and access water from the multiple hand-pumps in the village. There are specific handpumps from which water can be used for drinking, while the rest supply water mainly for other uses like washing and bathing. 18 families use an in-house toilet and 19 families use an in-house bathroom. While many other structures have been created through government schemes, the lack of plumbing and water access restricts their usage and most people still defecate and bathe in the open.

Similarly for cooking, quite a few houses have received LPG cylinders from the government, but since the refills are expensive the usage is restricted to making tea or when something has to be cooked urgently. All households primarily cook on a *chulha*

[10] nrega
[11] Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana - Gramin

with wood / dung. They also prefer the taste of food prepared this way, and some women hesitate to use the cylinders since they are not confident about its operating mechanism.

All households have electricity. There are cuts throughout the year, but especially during monsoons. 97 houses have a fan, 5 have a television and 4 have refrigerators (which are sometimes received as wedding gifts, and not purchased).

The closest market for regular household needs comprising vegetables, fruits, stationery, and banking, amongst others is ~17 km away, and 55 families have motorized 2-wheelers, while others are dependent on the local private services that ply twice a day.

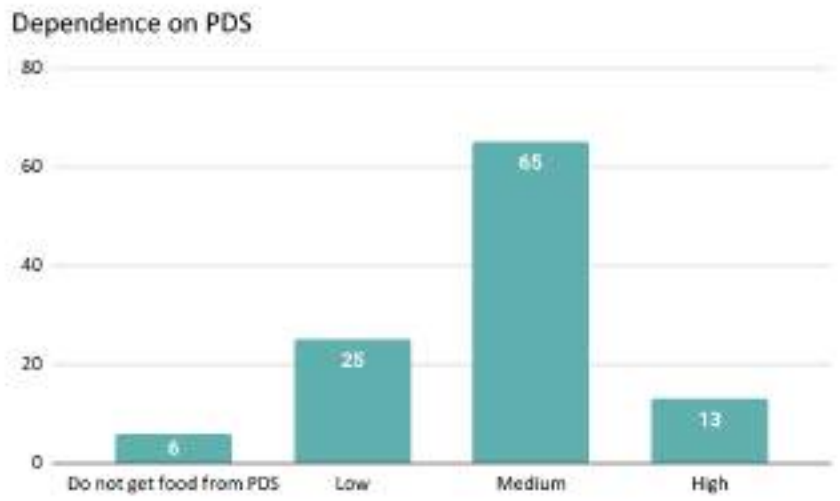
Infrastructure	
Pucca road	0.5km
Primary school	1km
High school / university (upto 12th)	1km
Post 12th	60km
Public health centres	17km
Sub health centres	70km
Pvt Hospital	8km
Electricity	In village
Phone network	In village
Internet services	In village
Water pipes (exist or not)	Not exist
Water source (well, hand pump, public tap)	Handpump / well
Entitlements	
Post office	2km
PDS (public distribution system)	3km
ICDS (integrated child development services)	1km
CSC (common service centers)	3km
Financial services	
Bank	17km
Functional ATM	17km
Transport	
Gas station	17km
Public bus	17km
Pvt bus	17km
Pvt auto / taxi	close to village
Trains	70km
Other	
Supermarket / kirana / pharmacy (basic needs)	17km
Theatre	115km
Hotel	17km

Education

Within the village, education institutions exist for children studying up to the 12th grade, including a Maa-wadi school for toddlers, though the closest institution for higher education is available only 60 kms away. 156 students are currently pursuing their education, of which 32 have completed 10th grade and are studying further. There are 10 children below the age of 5 who are eligible and have not yet enrolled in the Maa-wadi for various reasons. 18 children between 6 and 18 who have discontinued their studies, 3 of whom have not studied at all, 8 of them at or before 8th grade, 5 at 10th grade and 2 at 12th grade.

Health and nutrition

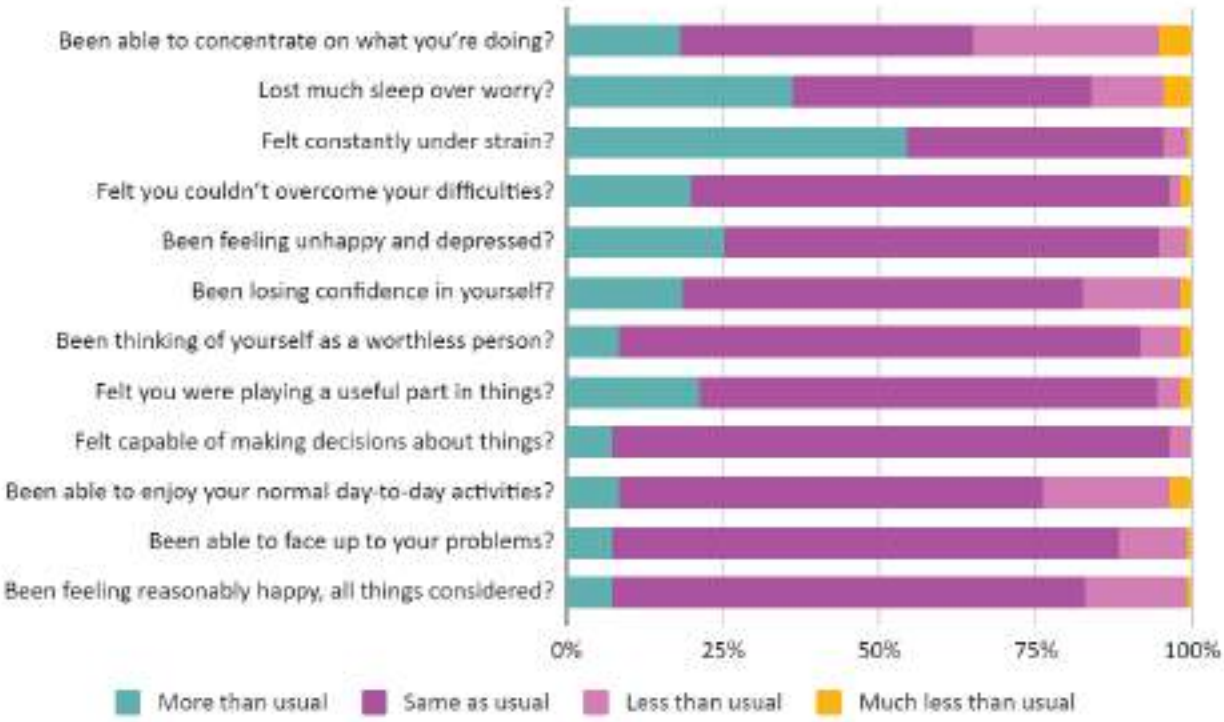
Nutrition: A daily meal comprises thick wheat rotis and *daal*. Rice and vegetables are eaten sometimes and *daal batti* is made on special occasions. 37% families report shortage of food few times a month, of which 4 are extreme cases where upto 10 days a month of smaller meals can occur. Only 10 families consume meat sometimes.



Those who have a low - medium dependence on PDS are generally able to make ends meet by consuming what they grow in their own fields.

Physical health: A large part of the population lack any major ailments. 82 people have some ongoing medication or are unable to work due to injury or illness. Most likely these are age related ailments. Others include kidney stones (potentially due to the quality of the water in the handpump with increased iron content), stomach knot, uterus removal, asthma, weak eyesight, occupational injuries. Most people prefer to visit a private clinic or hospital. There is a doctor who routinely visits the village, who some village members resort to as well. The Asha worker is mainly focussed on supporting pregnant women.

Wellbeing related: We also administered the GHQ-12 to understand overall stress levels. The GHQ-12 scale involves 12 questions about emotional state each with a four-level response scale. We interviewed 44 men and 67 women. On an average most people reported doing 'same as usual' on most indicators. Only feeling constantly under strain was more than usual for 55% of the surveyed people.



There is social cohesion visible where neighbours, friends and relatives are available to celebrate together and support one another in times of need, through monetary and non-monetary means.

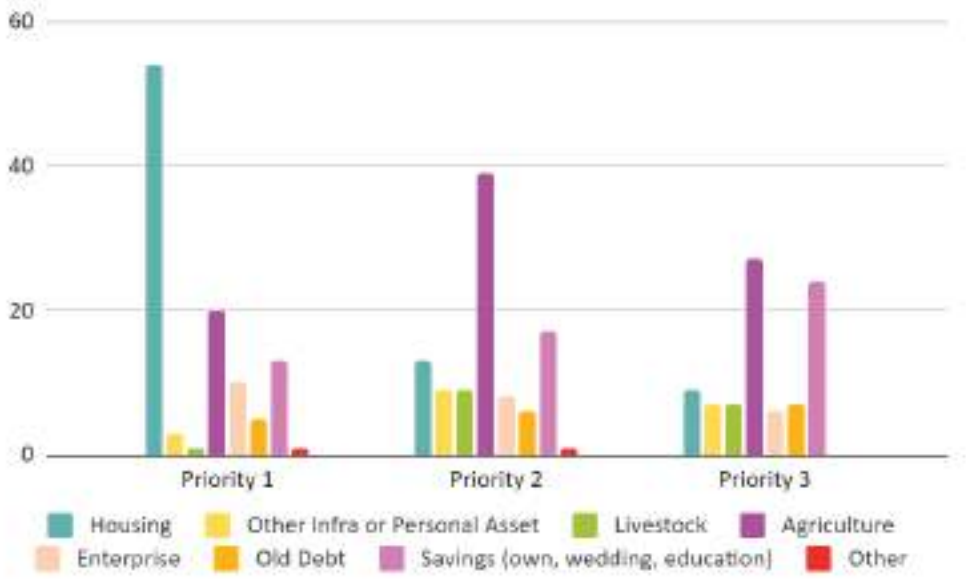
Substance Use

In the tribal communities in Rajasthan, there is a Bhagat andolan, which has a social and religious leader who follows and promotes the Govind Guru ideology. The hamlets in Sada follow this leader, and therefore do not consume meat and alcohol. There is also a Shiv mandir ~25kms away at Bhadreshwar, where there is a confluence of three rivers. The local guru there preaches adherence to a similar philosophy.

Many attribute their abstinence to the temple in the village that is a source of faith and serves as a community gathering space. Those who do indulge most likely do it outside the village or in their own space out of fear of social stigma. Two households reported alcohol consumption and 16 households mentioned bidi / cigarette smoking, and 51 individuals indulge in chewing tobacco. [Note: these factors were not known at the time of exposure visits, and were not a criteria for selection.]

Aspirations

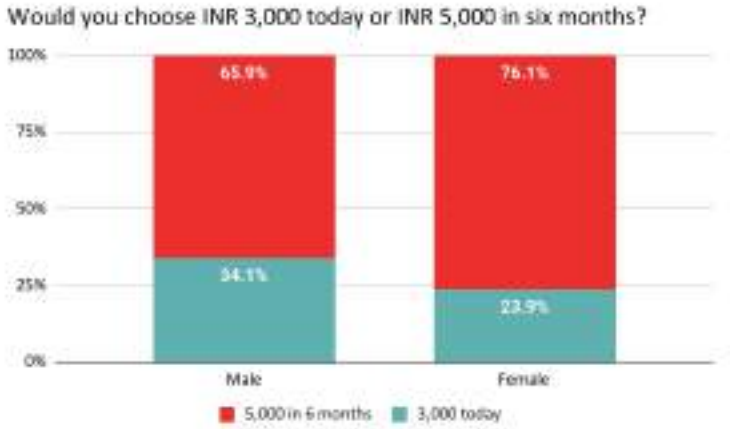
When asked about the three things that could transform their lives, the most common response was related to housing, followed by improved agriculture. Those who were unable to respond spontaneously, simply stated that they would save to ensure a better future for their children.



Risk and Time Preference



The fairly equal results show that half people have a risk appetite to test their luck, while half would rather go with the safer option and take what they are getting for sure.



Our hypothesis is that for those whom there is an urgent need of money, or who are quite old, the immediate option is more appealing. For others, waiting 6 months seemed more appropriate. There is also an underlying assumption of trust here, where those who do not believe that this option will remain available in six months, may have opted for the INR 3,000 today.

The Implementation Process

Exposure Visits

We visited Rajasthan in July 2023 with the objective of conducting recess. Our trip was planned and navigated by the Shram Sarathi team, especially Vishnu Bunkar who leads operations in the Bhabrana zone. We visited multiple locations including Sada Manpur, Devla financial inclusion clinic, Devla Kathal Phala, Badliya Phala, Hadmatiya, Ghated, Sada Amali Phala, Okhala Nedi Phala, Salumbar office, Bhabrana office BHS' Bedawal Clinic and Pradan's site at Dholakakar.

Given our criteria of a tribal village with potential to saturate nearby hamlets in forthcoming years, high stress and high opportunity regions - two villages were shortlisted by the Shram Sarathi team - Sada and Jogiyo ka Guda. Given that we had personally visited Sada, interacted with the community and knew of their aspirations firsthand, which we believe could be aided with an infusion of cash, we finalised this as our implementation village. Within this, Amali phala was chosen first for the same reason and then nearby hamlets were added based on population size to meet our target of 100 households.

Fundraising

We had four key funders for this program. Milind Kothari, Managing Partner at BDO India funded the program in his individual capacity, and held a fundraiser for all his employees to participate in the true spirit of CSR. Shehnaaz Memorial Trust and Ankit Gems provided repeat funding, increasing their contribution for this program. We continue to partner with DJED Foundation for this program and disbursement for one hamlet was conducted by them.

Baseline Surveys

We returned in November 2023 and began our baseline surveys (Appendix A) in the three hamlets, after a quick village meeting explaining that we wanted to understand the problems and aspirations of the people better. The detailed methodology has been explained in a separate section above.



We onboarded two local volunteers, Narayanlal Meena and Keshav Lal Meena to support us with surveys, especially to navigate the language barriers. We were also joined on ground by Vinay Jha (PhD scholar, IIMA), Nirved Kumar (PhD scholar, IIMA), Khushali Mehta (Team DEEP) and Sandip Deore (Founder, Yung Foundation) who supported with the surveys too. Each survey took between 30-50 mins and we completed these with 109 households within 10 days. During this time, we stayed in the village and were hosted by Narayanji. This helped us interact with the villagers in an informal capacity as well, and witness their daily lives more closely.

Program Announcement

We announced the cash transfer program in Sada on 27th November 2023. The Shram Sarathi team and Narayanji were a great support in organising the two rounds - one with the people at Amali phala and Mana Mangri, and the next one at Kadiya Mangri.

The announcement focuses on the key characteristics of the design which are that the program is meant for the development of families and the villages as a whole, people would be accountable for their own progress, individual households could determine which woman of the family would receive the transfer, and that the amount would not have to be returned. We stressed the last to differentiate between our program and Shram Sarathi's.



There was also a brief mention of fraud prevention. When we announced that each household would receive INR 65,000, there were happy faces and laughter all around.



Disbursement

This time the household members decided which woman the money would be transferred to, and we collected bank account details accordingly. Disbursement was a smooth process. A majority of the transfers were done in two tranches of bulk NEFT (National Electronics Funds Transfer)[12]. Transfers to a few women who had to check their activation status or were unavailable in the village at the time, were made subsequently.

We then engaged a banking correspondent to visit the village to check if the amounts had been received so that we could provide everyone with the final signed receipt. During this time, Shram Sarathi also did an awareness camp on insurance, renewed policies of those who had enrolled, and disbursed new policies as well.

The entire process was completed within a week.

[12] NEFT is an electronic payment system developed by RBI to facilitate transfer of funds by customers from one bank to another bank in India. It is a secured, economical, reliable and efficient system of funds transfer between banks.

Immediate Utilisation

In just 2-3 days, we saw a roof being built, some silver being purchased, land being levelled and compound boundaries coming up.



*Ramlal and his wife decided to **level the land** with an unconditional grant to increase the area under cultivation, increasing the yield, improving consumption and saving on food costs.*



*Chandulal decided to **create a borewell** to improve water access which will ensure increased agricultural output every year and create potential to grow vegetables throughout the year.*



*Balkrishna and his wife were able to finally **build the roof** of their house, that has been under construction for close to five years.*

Learnings

Surveys at Scale: On all days there were two teams of two conducting surveys to ensure effective utilisation of time. A key learning is that more time needs to be spent on alignment and understanding of the form and responses, and that end of the day discussions are instrumental to learn from each others' experience.

Analysing subjective indicators: Questions around wellbeing were not contextualised and responses do not reveal much about the stressors or motivators. We are looking to either understand from experts what alternatives can be used, or build our capacity to administer these in an improved manner.

Household determination criteria: It helped us to have a local understanding of what parameters people use to consider a family as a unit i.e. we had three criteria (living under a separate roof, cooking separately or having separate finances) of which two had to be met for an individual / group to be considered an independent household. This enabled us to clarify doubts and mitigate concerns on inclusion and exclusion.

Here in Sada, the older son typically moves out of his parents' home with his family, once his younger brother gets married. We came across a few families in the transition period, due to a recent wedding in the family or in the process of building a new house. In such cases, sometimes despite living together in a physical structure, individual family units (husband and wife) may cook separate meals from the other (parents, siblings / in-laws).

Implementation Partner

Shram Sarathi was set up to enable financial inclusion of communities dependent on migration and labour via provision of financial services. They have a field-based model and operate through rural and semi-urban branches located in underserved block areas/ tehsils in Rajasthan. In order to enable financial inclusion, their key offerings are micro-loans, returnable grants, emergency grants, and financial and digital literacy clinics. Their strong on ground team has developed a deep understanding of the community, their needs, and the drivers of behaviors.

The whole team, especially Vishnu Bunkar, Limbaram, Neha Pandey, Rajmal Kulmi and Ajay Sharma played a significant part in the successful implementation of the program.

The team planned and accompanied us through the entire exposure visit, to locations with different characteristics in terms of demographic, topography, infrastructure and access to markets and basic necessities, for us to be able to gauge the landscape better. Post our visit, they did their own internal analysis to shortlist two villages for our potential implementation, engaging the extended teams who worked closer to the ground.

Once the village was finalised, identifying suitable volunteers, arranging for our accommodation, mobilising the community for meetings and introducing us was all ably done by the Shram Sarathi team. The trust that the community has on them and their work made it easy for us to engage with people and conduct the surveys smoothly. All program announcements were done by Vishnuji, Limbaram and Neha to ensure correct messaging in the local language, and to address any doubts or clarifications as required.

Even as we return to Mumbai, their presence on ground gives us the comfort of continuity and ensures that people have access to those who will be able to address any challenges or support they may need.

Stories from Sada

Migration Tales

We were living in the village, at Narayanji's home, during the baseline surveys. On our first night there, some men came over to sit and give us company and speak to us, since there is little to do there post sunset. They shared their stories of migration, experience of the pandemic and the current situation. The struggle to earn a decent income starts with not having enough money to travel long distances to the cities where there are opportunities. And once that hurdle is somehow overcome by a few, living in the destination regions is an expensive and stressful affair. Before the pandemic, they used to manage by living on the streets but are now charged for this as well, and sometimes subjected to police brutality. The non-availability of risk capital to manage a few days of expenses while they look for a suitable work opportunity. There were a few men who had managed to save certain amounts or taken debt to set up their own chai or snacks stalls in Ahmedabad, after decades of being working as employees. However, the pandemic struck soon after, and their investments proved to be sunk costs. Not only that, they also had to incur debt to pay for a few months rent, since no one knew how long the lockdown would last. These folks now have a higher debt burden to grapple with. They are trapped in the vicious cycle of not being able to earn well, due to the lack of money to invest in fruitful enterprises. However, their exposure through living and working in cities makes them extremely knowledgeable about how to manage finances and think of development.

The setbacks of a medical crisis

Through our stay at Narayanji's house, we learnt of his story too. He has received skill training and was at the brink of a stable and financially viable job when a series of medical crises hit his family. After losing his father, he stayed back at home to look after his ailing mother for almost three years. Around this time, he also lost his brother and now has the responsibility to support an additional family of his sister in law and two children. The event of death also has high expenses associated with it, to host and feed the entire village and conduct customary rituals. Narayanji is the sole income earner in the two families. Despite having a reasonable qualification, the three years of high expenses, low income and debt has set him back significantly. He now juggles three jobs, working as a night security guard in a nearby district, volunteering with Aajeevika Bureau and Shram Sarathi and managing local governance related matters, apart from engaging in agriculture. He is extremely aspirational and wants to build a better life for himself and

his family. His story is representative of many people that we interact with, but not all of them have the access and opportunity to turn things around in time.

Lack of jobs for graduate women

In Sada, mostly men migrate to earn a living and women engage in daily wage labour either through MNREGA or a few days work at each other's farms during harvest season. We interacted with a few women who had been married into the village, and had qualifications as high as graduate level, but no access to job opportunities. Anita is a stand out example here, who has set up her own shop selling artificial jewellery and other women products. She is one of the few who has an avenue to spend her time in a different manner, and contribute financially to the household.

Inaccessible job opportunities due to poor foundational education

There are other challenges with education and jobs as well. A young boy in his early 20s was sharing his plight. Education is free for everyone until 8th grade, and mostly students pass irrespective of their performance in exams. Certain subjects like English may not even have regular teachers. This results in a false sense of progress, such that when students enter 9th grade, they are neither prepared for the subject matter nor the rigour of upper secondary school. For those who make their way to graduation, the competitive exams prove to be extremely difficult since their base is weak. Largely, this makes them ineligible for formal desk jobs. And the lack of counselling to match them to more appropriate jobs has resulted in desolation and confusion for the youth.

Expanding horizons

The concept of cash transfers is new for the local team of Shram Sarathi in Sada. But as we stayed and conversed more with them, their curiosity started building. Once the money was disbursed, Limbaram, who was our main point of contact, was extremely pleased when he saw a roof being constructed. He shared that this home had been incomplete for the past five years since he had first joined. He also had his concerns about the financial prudence of the male head (of this particular household) and his ability to use the money well. He was happy to see how the lumpsum received during the program was being used, and how it had finally propelled the family into action.

The On-ground Team



From Left to Right as related to Project DEEP: Muzamil Baig (team), Sandeep Devre (partner), Keshavlal Meena (volunteer), Narayanlal Meena (volunteer and host), Pankhuri Shah (team), Khushali Mehta (team)



From Left to Right: Khushali Mehta, Sandeep Devre, Prachi Joshi, Pankhuri Shah, Ajay Kumar Sharma, (holding Viraj Sharma) Muzamil Baig, Kishan Gurjar, Mukesh Meghwal, Panna Lal Dangi, Rajmal Kulmi, Pratap Singh, Vishnu Bunkar



From Left to Right (as related to Project DEEP): Narayanlal Meena (Volunteer), Pankhuri Shah (Team), Vinay Kumar Jha (Research Scholar), Nirved Kumar Verma (Research Scholar), Keshavlal Meena (Volunteer), Muzamil Baig (Team)

Conclusion

Our hypothesis is that the lumpsum transfers will act as the oil required to make the stalled engines of Sada propel forward towards prosperity. We are encouraged by the early utilisation and hope that these stories will serve as inspiration for the rest of the community to invest money for their own development. We trust in people's ability to seize the opportunities that lead to their wellbeing, and believe that evidence from Sada will further our case to build a strong ecosystem of cash transfer programs in India.

Way Forward

We will conduct a utilisation survey in March 2024 to understand where the money was used and what was the process of decision making for the same. Followed by a visit in November 2024 for conducting an annual assessment.

Contact us:
Muzamil Baig - + 91 9819269709 | muzamil@project-deep.org
Pankhuri Shah - +91 9619057586 | pankhuri@project-deep.org
www.project-deep.org

Appendix A - Baseline Survey Questionnaire

Please refer to our complete baseline survey questionnaire here.

The overall questionnaire has undergone multiple rounds of reviews from our research team constituting PhD scholars from esteemed institutes. Certain changes were also made based on our experience and learnings from the Krishnapur Project:

- Detailed questions around materials used to build walls, roof and floor and combined it to understand whether the overall structure was pucca or kucha, putting a specific definition for these. This was done since the change anticipated through the program can be identified through the consolidated question, rather than multiple ones.
- We also added questions around risk and time preference, to try and gauge factors of decision making.
- The nutrition question was nuanced to understand the frequency of consumption of vegetables and meat, to make it more specific and easy to answer instead of the broad question on the overall components of a meal.
- Details on migration were asked specifically, given the context of the demographic.
- Further sub-questions to the Income segment were added to understand wages from agricultural labor and non-agriculture jobs.
- In the expense segment, an additional question on non-routine expenses that are incurred throughout the year, including clothing and social costs was added to get a more comprehensive picture of total outflow.
- In the debt segment, repercussions on non-repayment and priority of repayment were added to ascertain people's understanding of their overall debt.
- The Kessler Psychological Distress scale was replaced with the GHQ-12, given the need for a broader and more contextual scale.
- We have also not maintained a control group this time, given the moral dilemma of committing to conducting the program with them in the next year.

The survey is conducted through the offline version of jotform, through door to door interactions with all participating households. The data is then collated, cleaned up and analysed on excel.

A key factor is that the data is self reported and no checks and audits are a part of the process. This sometimes causes minor variances in the data, of which a few points can be adjusted based on the overall trend and majority responses. For eg: the price of petrol for daily wage commuter migrants can be cross verified based on the trend of responses and the average number quoted by majority of the respondents. Similarly for the cost of living for circular migrants.

Local volunteers with regional context and language fluency accompany us through this process, to ensure that the survey is effectively administered.

Appendix B - About Scheduled Tribes

The Scheduled Tribes are notified in 30 States/UTs and the number of individual ethnic groups, etc. notified as Scheduled Tribes is 705. The tribal population of the country, as per the 2011 census, is 10.43 crore, constituting 8.6% of the total population. 89.97% of them live in rural areas and 10.03% in urban areas.[13]

Tribal communities typically live in hills, forests, coastal, and desert areas with their communities, having their own cultural, social, and political system. The consequences of isolation from the mainstream economy are what makes them extremely vulnerable.

Economic: The tribal economy is dependent on forests and agriculture. Given that a large number of tribals are landless or possess small parcels of land which result in small yields, most of the population lives below the poverty line.

Debt and bonded labor: Low bargaining power and lack of resources create a vicious cycle of debt and sometimes even bonded labor, that tribal population finds difficult to break out of.

Education: Children start working in the fields at a young age and the cost of education combined with the loss of wages by losing one pair of hands is high. Education is not contextualized for the ST community, including the medium of instruction, and institutions are not close to their habitats causing the literacy gap to widen.

Unemployment: The lack of education, and their concentration in rural locations results in higher levels of unemployment. Those who migrate for work are often subject to exploitation and oppression.

Nutrition and health: Monetary poverty and lack of access to necessities of clean water and hygiene lead to poor health conditions. Higher out-of-pocket expenses to address these, further push them deeper into the poverty trap.

Tribal groups face discrimination due to social stigma, hindering access to schemes and entitlements, legal redressal, and formal finance institutions which are key levers to aid socio-economic progress.

[13] Scheduled Tribes in India — Vikaspedia.